relentlessness of the challenge. Their survival gene is also deeply ingrained; they know careers are getting shorter and more intense.

Like it or not, sport at the highest level is not a friendly environment. During my twelve years with England I began to get a sense of who would thrive and who would fall away relatively quickly. It wouldn't be fair to name him, but one guy, a younger player who had excelled in county cricket, came to me soon after his call-up. 'This is very intense, isn't it?' he said. 'I didn't expect that.' I knew he was lost. That's what it is. Hard. Pitiless. Unforgiving.

The weeding out process begins early. That fifteen-strong England Under-19 squad, judged in hindsight, was probably above par, since seven of us, Samit Patel, Ravi Bopara, Steven Davies, Luke Wright, Tim Bresnan, Liam Plunkett and I, progressed to play senior international cricket.

James Hildreth, who has scored in excess of 16,000 first-class runs for Somerset, can count himself unlucky not to have been given an opportunity in England's middle order. James is one of the finest county players of my generation. We go way back; his father used to pick me up from Newport Pagnell services on the M1 and ferry us to and from our training sessions at Loughborough University. We were roommates and partners on *Tiger Woods* golf, during the Under-19 World Cup in Bangladesh in 2004. His one taste of the big time was an appearance as substitute fielder in the 2005 Ashes series, when he caught Ricky Ponting off Matthew Hoggard in the first Test at Lord's.

The fate of others reflects the uncertainty, misfortune and disappointment of professional sport. David Stiff, a fast bowler who took 4–7 against Uganda in one of the group games in Bangladesh, was courted by a dozen counties when he opted to leave Yorkshire. He played twenty first-class matches for Kent, Leicestershire and Somerset, who released him after the 2010 season.

Wicketkeeper-batsman Tom New settled for the role of long-term understudy to Paul Nixon at Leicestershire until 2011. Mark Turner, a medium-fast right-arm bowler, played for three counties over nine years until 2014. Leg-spinner Mark Lawson moved into developmental coaching. Dan Broadbent, a left-handed batsman, didn't make a first-class appearance. Adam Harrison was forced to retire in 2007 due to a persistent ankle injury.

It is sobering to see a career, the destiny of someone's dream, summed up in a single sentence. But that is the way of things. Judgement is harsh, often